

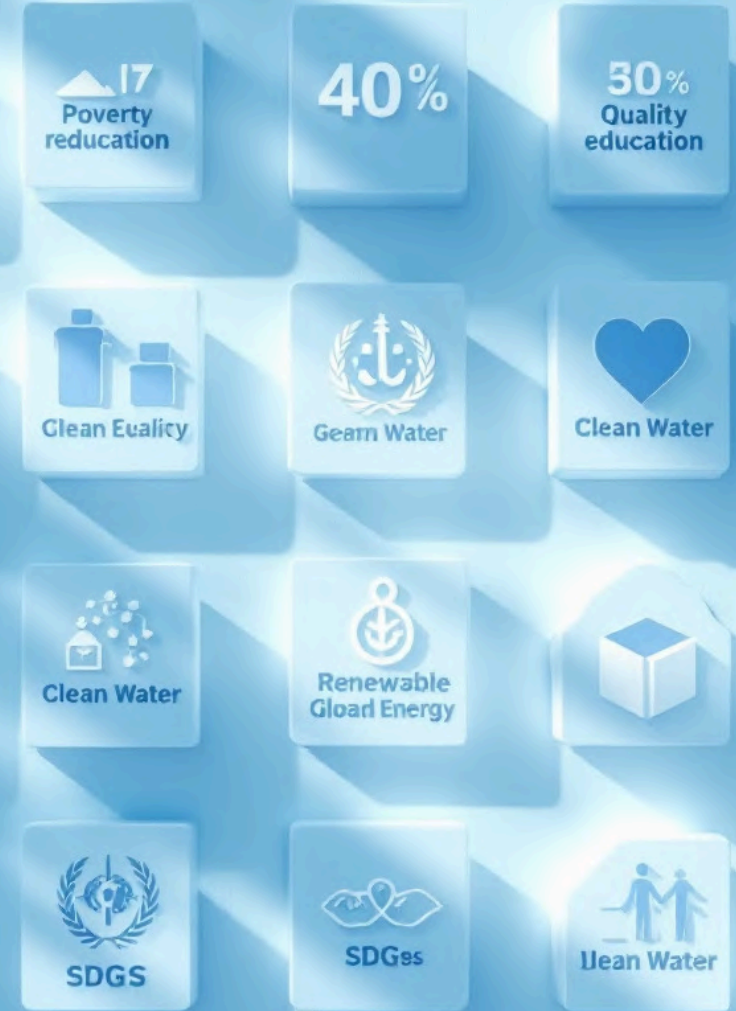
GLOBAL AGENDA

MODERN STORIES OF INDIA

Our commitment to the **United Nations Sustainable Development Goals**

India is driving transformation through targeted initiatives that address core challenges of sustainability, social equity, and economic growth.

- ✓ Focusing on 17 interconnected objectives to ensure a prosperous future for all citizens.



Themes in Modern Indian Short Stories & SDGs

Communicative English: Project Based Learning

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Overview of the Collection

The Penguin Book of Modern Indian Short Stories

Edited by **Stephen Alter** and **Wimal Dissanayake**

This anthology brings together a landmark collection of short fiction that captures the **vibrancy and profound diversity** of modern Indian literature. By curating works from varied cultural and linguistic landscapes, the editors offer a window into the evolution of Indian narrative voices.

Key Themes

- **Poverty & Economic Struggle**
- **Gender Inequality**
- **Migration & Displacement**
- **Family Dynamics**
- **Social & Political Change**

① These stories, originally crafted in native languages, provide an authentic lens through which we explore the **complexities of modern Indian society** and its realistic, enduring characters.



The **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)**, established by the United Nations in 2015, are the heart of the **2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development**. This global framework serves as a universal call to action to end poverty, protect the planet, and ensure that by 2030 all people enjoy peace and prosperity.

-  **The 17 Goals:** Designed to address the interconnected challenges of poverty, inequality, climate change, environmental degradation, peace, and justice.

These goals prioritize improving global quality of life by focusing on:

Access to food, quality education, healthcare, and clean water.

Promoting economic growth, responsible consumption, and environmental protection.

Ensuring gender equality and fostering peaceful, inclusive societies.

Achieving these ambitious goals requires **global cooperation** and **sustainable policy-making**. By committing to responsible resource management today, we can secure a resilient, thriving future for both people and the planet. 🌍



Selected Stories and Authors

Explore a curated collection of literary masterpieces from renowned voices.



"Books are a uniquely portable magic."

1 The Discovery of Telenapota
Premendra Mitra

3 Nostalgia
Bharati Mukherjee

5 Another Community
R.K. Narayan

2 The Weed
Amrita Pritam

4 A Devoted Son
Anita Desai



The Discovery of Telenapota

Premendra Mitra: Author Insight

A pioneering Bengali writer whose work masterfully explores **human emotion, deep-seated loneliness, and the stark realities of societal life.**

In "*The Discovery of Telenapota*," Mitra constructs a **mysterious, isolated setting** to examine the fragility of hope and the crushing weight of social neglect.

Story Summary

The narrative follows three friends whose fishing trip leads them to the desolate, ruined village of Telenapota. There, they encounter **Jamini**, who dwells in a dilapidated home with her ailing mother.

- The mother, clinging to the past, mistakes the narrator for **Niranjan**, a man promised to marry her daughter.
- The narrator, moved by the moment, offers a false promise of marriage to comfort the dying woman.
- Ultimately, the narrator abandons Telenapota, leaving Jamini to her **inevitable cycle of poverty and isolation.**



Connected SDGs

Exploring the intersection of rural isolation and global development goals.

SDG 1: No Poverty

The story illustrates the cycle of poverty and social neglect in Telenapota:

- **Systemic Decay:** Telenapota represents a deserted landscape where development has completely halted.
- **Extreme Vulnerability:** Jamini and her mother suffer from a lack of stable income, basic infrastructure, and social safety nets.
- **Cycle of Despair:** The narrative captures how **poverty traps individuals** in roles of dependence and hopelessness.

SDG 3: Good Health and Well-Being

The absence of medical infrastructure highlights a failure to provide basic health services:

- **Poor Sanitation:** The prevalence of mosquitoes points to rampant disease risks like malaria.
- **Medical Neglect:** Chronic conditions, like the mother's blindness and fragility, go untreated due to **total isolation from healthcare facilities**.
- **Critical Needs:** The story underscores the vital necessity for disease prevention and accessible clinical support in rural regions.



SDG 5: Gender Equality

Jamini's life reflects the systemic limitations faced by women in traditional societies, where futures are often dictated by marriage rather than personal agency.

- Dependent on **Niranjan's return** for social stability.
- Lack of access to **education, employment, or personal independence**.
- Sacrificing personal dreams to fulfill **caretaking roles**.

❖ The narrative serves as a poignant call for **equal opportunities** and the **empowerment of women**.

SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities

The story exposes the stark contrast between the urban, privileged background of the narrator and the perpetual isolation of Telenapota.

- **Adventure vs. Reality:** Temporary visitation versus lifelong entrapment.
- Geographic **exclusion from national development**.
- Systemic **social and economic disparities**.

❖ Highlighting the urgent need to bridge the gap and ensure **equitable access to progress**.



Story 2: "The Weed"

Author Introduction – Amrita Pritam

Amrita Pritam was a pioneering Indian author and poet, globally recognized for her evocative writing on social injustice and the female experience. In her poignant story "**The Weed**," she masterfully critiques the traditional dogmas that stifle women's agency, advocating for fundamental **gender equality**.

Short Story Summary – *The Weed*

The narrative centers on **Angoori**, a village girl raised within a patriarchal framework that views **female education as a transgression**. Taught that knowledge is "sinful," she remains trapped by rigid communal customs.

The title "**weed**" serves as a powerful metaphor for suppressed female potential. Just as a weed is denied the space to flourish, society systematically stunts the growth and intellectual independence of women like Angoori.

- ③ The story serves as a critical reflection on how **systemic discrimination** and lack of access to education perpetuate cycles of dependence and limit the horizons of women in rural societies.



Connected SDGs

The themes of Amrita Pritam's "The Weed" serve as a poignant reflection of modern development goals, illustrating the critical need for systemic change.



SDG 5: Gender Equality

In the story, the girl is compared to a **weed**—something unnoticed and ignored. This symbolizes how **society often treats women as unimportant**.

- Growing up without proper care or attention
- Reflecting a **patriarchal attitude** where women's value is diminished
- Restricting dreams, independence, and the **need for equal respect and empowerment**



SDG 4: Quality Education

The girl's journey illustrates the consequences of **neglect and a lack of developmental opportunities** in her community.

- Education acts as a **vital tool for empowerment and progress**
- The neglect shown highlights the **critical lack of education and awareness**
- Emphasizing the connection to SDG 4 by showing how **access to learning drives independence**

Impact on Future Generations

By addressing these two SDGs, we can break the cycle of suppression that defines the protagonist's life, fostering an environment where growth is nurtured rather than stifled.

Call to Action

The story serves as a mirror for current societal shortcomings, urging us to provide **inclusive, equitable quality education** to all girls.



Addressing Systemic Issues

Analyzing the narrative through the lens of global sustainable development goals.

SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities



The narrative exposes deep-seated disparities:

- Unequal treatment rooted in **gender and social expectations**.
- Systemic barriers limiting **opportunities and social mobility**.
- The critical need to dismantle **prejudicial status hierarchies**.

SDG 16: Peace, Justice & Institutions



Highlighting the failure of social support structures:

- Critique of **discriminatory social norms**.
- The vulnerability of those neglected by **institutional apathy**.
- A call for societies to uphold **dignity, respect, and fundamental rights**.

Key Takeaway

By challenging these injustices, the story aligns with the global mission to build **inclusive, peaceful, and equitable societies** where every individual has the agency to thrive.



Story 3: "Nostalgia"

Author: [Bharati Mukherjee](#)

Bharati Mukherjee was an Indian-born American writer renowned for exploring themes of **migration**, **cultural identity**, and the immigrant experience. Her work captures the emotional friction of adapting to new cultures while tethered to a homeland. In "**Nostalgia**," she masterfully depicts the inner turmoil of an immigrant caught between his past and his present.

Summary: "Nostalgia"

The narrative centers on **Dr. Patel**, an Indian immigrant in the U.S. who has meticulously reconstructed his identity to mirror American norms, distancing himself from his roots.

- ③ The arrival of a couple from his past triggers a profound **identity crisis**, exposing the futility of trying to abandon one's heritage. The story serves as a poignant look at the **struggle for belonging** in a new land.



Connected SDGs



SDG 1: No Poverty

- Focuses on **poor and marginalized communities**.
- Reflects constant **struggles for survival** with limited resources.
- Highlights how poverty directly undermines **dignity and opportunity**.
- Exposes the impact of **social neglect**.



SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities

- Illustrates the **growing gap** between the powerful and the marginalized.
- Highlights systemic **social and economic exclusion**.
- Demonstrates how inequality acts as a **barrier to personal progress**.
- Advocates for **equitable policy change**.

 The story serves as a narrative lens through which we can analyze the real-world impact of these Global Goals on vulnerable populations.

SDG Impact Analysis

3. SDG 8 – Decent Work and Economic Growth

Characters in the story struggle to find **stable and dignified jobs**.



- Lack of employment opportunities **keeps people trapped in poverty**.
- The story highlights the importance of **fair jobs and economic security**.
- Relates to **SDG 8**, promoting decent work and sustainable livelihoods.

4. SDG 16 – Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions

The narrative addresses **social injustice and exploitation** of vulnerable groups.



- Systems meant to protect people often **fail to provide fairness**.
- Highlights the vital need for **justice, human rights, and strong institutions**.
- Aligned directly with the core objectives of **SDG 16**.

These thematic connections demonstrate how the narrative mirrors real-world developmental challenges.



Story 4: "A Devoted Son"

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Anita Desai

Anita Desai is a renowned Indian author whose work explores the intricate landscape of **human relationships, family conflicts, and psychological depth**. Her narratives often dissect the tension between individual ambition and societal duty.

📖 In "**A Devoted Son**," Desai masterfully examines the complex power dynamics between a father and son, surfacing themes of **duty, expectations, and the paradox of success**.

STORY SUMMARY

The Trajectory of Devotion

The story follows **Rakesh**, a model of diligence who rises from humble beginnings to become a successful doctor. While he is initially celebrated for his commitment to his father, **Varma**, the story takes a poignant turn:

The Conflict of Care

Rakesh enforces a strict, disciplined health regimen to prolong his father's life, driven by his medical expertise.

The Weight of Expectations

Varma feels **constricted and stripped of his autonomy**, viewing his son's "devotion" as a form of imprisonment.

This narrative forces us to confront the thin line between **filial duty** and **paternal autonomy**, revealing how success can fundamentally alter the intimacy of family ties.



Connected SDGs

The story of "A Devoted Son" provides a powerful lens through which we can examine global development goals.

SDG 4: Quality Education



Rakesh's journey from a modest background to a successful doctor illustrates the transformative power of education.

- Success driven by **diligent study and hard work**.
- Education as a catalyst for **social mobility and improved status**.
- Creation of **better living standards** through professional expertise.

SDG 3: Good Health & Well-Being



The narrative explores the intersection of professional medical care and the personal challenges of aging.

- Rakesh serves as a **dedicated practitioner** for his community.
- Focus on **preventative care and disciplined healthy habits**.
- Highlights the complexity of **managing physical health within family dynamics**.



SDG 10 – Reduced Inequalities

Rakesh's journey from a **modest family background** to becoming a **respected doctor** serves as a powerful example of social mobility.



- Through **education and relentless hard work**, he breaks socio-economic barriers.
- His success proves that **equitable opportunities** are essential for improving status.
- This directly mirrors the core mission of **reducing inequalities**.

SDG 8 – Decent Work & Growth

His career as a doctor exemplifies **professional dedication** and the role of high-skilled labor in society.



- Employment provides **financial stability** and hard-earned social respect.
- He contributes back to the economy by **maintaining public health**.
- His path highlights the value of **responsible, skilled employment**.



These goals collectively show how personal achievement drives sustainable development.



Learning Outcomes

By studying four impactful stories—**“The Discovery of Telenapota”**, **“The Weed”**, **“Nostalgia”**, and **“A Devoted Son”**—our project achieved the following key insights:



Understanding Social Issues

Gained insight into poverty, gender inequality, migration, and social neglect reflected through literature.



Global Goals Alignment

Bridged literary themes with **United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** for social development awareness.



Critical Thinking

Analyzed cultural dynamics and human relationships to sharpen our critical perspective on society.



Communication Skills

Developed the ability to organize complex ideas and present findings clearly and effectively.



Empathy Development

Built a deeper understanding and compassion for human experiences beyond our own realities.



Research & Collaboration

Enhanced teamwork and investigative skills through a comprehensive **Interdisciplinary Learning** approach.



Conclusion

This Project-Based Learning (PBL) initiative has been a profound journey into how literature serves as a mirror for **real-life social issues** and **human experiences**. Through the works of **Premendra Mitra, Amrita Pritam, Bharati Mukherjee**, and **Anita Desai**, we have explored critical themes:

Core Themes

Poverty, Gender Inequality, Migration, Education, Family Dynamics, and Social Injustice.

By bridging these narratives with the **United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)**, we have discovered that literature is more than storytelling; it is a catalyst for **global awareness** and **social change**. This project has significantly sharpened our skills in:

- **Literary Analysis:** Deepening our capacity to interpret complex social commentary.
- **Critical Thinking:** Connecting artistic narratives to systemic global challenges.
- **Communication:** Refining our ability to articulate ideas clearly and persuasively.
- **Sustainable Development:** Realizing our role in promoting a more equitable society.

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- ✓ We extend our deepest gratitude to our **Communicative English teacher** for this opportunity. Your guidance was instrumental in helping us navigate the intersection of literature and social advocacy. We also appreciate the collective support that allowed this project to flourish.

